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Famine, Affluence, and Propriety

In his 1972 essay *Famine, Affluence, and Morality*, Peter Singer argues for an ethical framework that commands an ambitious baseline for leading a moral life. Singer's line of reasoning concludes that those with the means to afford luxuries must donate the money they would otherwise spend on luxuries to humanitarian organizations. Although Singer makes a compelling case for both his strong and moderate versions of this principle, his submission to a strictly utilitarian ethical perspective falls short in addressing the complexity of moral obligations. I seek to establish how the ethical contrast between these versions distinguishes the manner in which the moderate principle prescribes a more lenient obligation than Singer concludes. First, I will explain both versions of the proposed ethical principle. Then, I will introduce my definition of luxuries under either system based on Singer's ethical recommendations. Next, I will argue that the moderate form contended by Singer accommodates greater levels of indulgence by contrasting it against the strong form and the variable definitions of luxury. Finally, I will investigate a potential response from Singer to my interpretation and how he may seek to reconcile that conflict.

Although Singer's line of reasoning explicitly only supports one of the proposed principle forms, Singer contends two forms that play the same role in governing his presented ethical framework throughout the essay: a strong form and a moderate form. In his strong form, which is

introduced initially by the line of reasoning and later qualified to a more moderate form, Singer asserts,

> *"If it is in our power to prevent something very bad from happening, without thereby sacrificing anything of comparable moral importance, we ought, morally, to do it."*[1]

Shortly thereafter, Singer qualifies this strong form to a moderate form, stating,

> *"If it is in our power to prevent something very bad from happening, without thereby sacrificing anything morally significant, we ought, morally, to do it."*[1]

Despite the initial appearance of this principle's dominant consequentialist inspiration, contradictory ethical schemes emerge as Singer clarifies it. Naturally, Singer highlights the consequentialist message by emphasizing that nothing comparably bad should be caused from a successful implementation of the principle. Following this, Singer incorporates a deontological message by affirming that one must not commit an action that is wrong in itself in execution of the principle. Singer closes this aspect of his analysis by stating that the application of the principle must not fail to promote the moral good, an ambiguous addition that enables the possibility of reinterpreting the moderate form, whether based on the above ethical systems or others. The strong form remains impervious to reinterpretation due to an addendum of Singer's

[1] Singer, Peter. "Famine, Affluence, and Morality." *Famine, Affluence, and Morality*, Oxford University Press, 2016, pp. 6-7.

explanation that dictates the aforementioned moral imperatives be upheld so long as they are of comparable moral significance to the "bad thing" that can be prevented. Despite the meta-moral significance of death being outstandingly outside the scope of Singer's essay, Singer remains confident in its comparable moral priority over any other sacrifice that could plausibly be made. Thus, under the strong form of the principle, not only can a vast majority of both moral and immoral actions be taken in the prevention of death, but also these actions must be taken. This results in the radical utilitarian execution proposed by Singer of diminishing material comfort to the point of "marginal utility," or where the sum of well-being throughout the world would diminish due to additional self-sacrifice doing comparably more harm than good. Although Singer claims this form as the correct one, he admits to its radical nature and thus spends the essay arguing for the relatively more palatable moderate version. He makes this shift for strategic reasons; However, as I will discuss, this approach paradoxically undermines the influence of the moderate form.

The difference between the two forms of the principle is best demonstrated through the two different definitions of what is morally permissible to spend resources on, specifically money. I will call these morally permissible actions 'obligations,' and classify everything else as 'luxuries.' According to the strong form, anything that is not required to stay above the inflection point of marginal utility is a luxury. Not only does this include material possessions and enjoyable experiences, but also, if the strong form is to be taken to the logical conclusion stated in the preceding paragraph, certain moral privileges. For instance, purchasing high quality yet expensive food becomes a luxury under the strong form. The suffering that one can alleviate by donating that money far outweighs the moral significance of supposed health benefits or taste preferences of the food. Singer admits that the strong form requires reducing oneself to the very

near material circumstances of a Bengali refugee. Selling one's house, changing one's diet, and living an exceptionally frugal lifestyle are all plausible outcomes of this form of the principle. Those actions may seem burdensome and undesirable, but they are not nearly as unpleasant as the suffering and death that can be alleviated. The well-being created globally greatly outweighs the personal comfort sacrificed. As stated earlier, this comfort may also be sacrificed in moral areas. Stealing from an ATM can be regarded as an immoral act, as stealing in itself is immoral, but it can be justified if it funds famine relief charities due to the consequences of each action. The validity of this conclusion bases itself on Singer's interpretation of the strong form that dictates an action as immoral only if its moral significance is comparable to the moral significance of preventing suffering and death. In the case of robbing an ATM or defrauding an insurance company, the consequences of financial loss of the company and certain individuals and inherent wrongness of theft are not of comparable moral importance to the alleviation of suffering or death. At no point does Singer argue for this conclusion based on his call to action, but the example elucidates how far Singer's strong form can be pushed for it to reach a seemingly absurd ethical conclusion. The difference in the moderate form, then, is how it resists this absurdity. The moderate form classifies luxuries as anything without moral significance. The difference between this definition and the definition presented by the strong form is the moral significance need not be comparable to alleviating suffering and death. The moral significance can be of any kind and amount, operating under Singer's assumption that moral significance is measurable. To take the food example, healthier yet more expensive foods may serve the moral purpose of promoting health, a virtuous good. Therefore, under the moderate form, actions gain nuance as they can be interpreted as serving different types of moral obligations.

As mentioned previously, Singer's argument contends the strong form of the principle, yet Singer's essay supports the moderate form. This strategy aims to strengthen the moderate form and enhance the persuasiveness of Singer's call to action in two ways. First, by sculpting the argument around the stricter, more morally constraining strong form, the moderate form receives additional favor by being a slightly more forgiving version. If the strong form is the case, then the moderate form must definitely be the case so long as the moderate form is consistent with the premises and is not merely extrapolated from the strong form. Which it achieves. Furthermore, Singer's position becomes more compelling by making his argument more palatable through the introduction of the moderate form. However, by creating this contrast, Singer's whole position becomes more lenient than he intends. The creation and discussion of the moderate form still calls for a more generous and charitable culture, but the altered commandment demands less of affluent societies than Singer declares. This is due to material possessions often purchased for some morally significant reason, although most of the time implicitly. Some of these implicit values can be artistry, craftsmanship, culture, mental and physical health, family, and community, which various frameworks deem supporting as morally significant. For example, purchasing an item Singer may identify as a luxury, such as a painting, supports a culture of artistic expression. It does not matter that this support is not morally comparable to alleviating suffering and death according to the moderate form. The duality of these forms ensnares Singer's argument into choosing between polarizing positions. Take for example the "Shallow Pond" thought experiment. Under the strong form, the choice not to save the drowning child for the sake of preserving nice clothing is an immoral and monstrous decision. Under the moderate form, however, this choice can be morally permissible so long as keeping the suit clean has any moral significance. Yet most people would agree that this is still a

choice that only an immoral monster would make. Thus, Singer's two contentions can sometimes fall short in finding a reasonable middle ground, oscillating between absurd ethical austerity and absurd ethical leniency.

The greatest issues Singer may raise to this analysis are in relation to the examples used. The qualification of Singer's principle implies that its execution should be context-dependent. If the context does not require the robbery of banking institutions for the sake of alleviating suffering, then that course of action should not be endorsed. Furthermore, in examples such as theft for a greater cause, Singer may argue that robbery does not guarantee any accruing of money, as the illegality of the act may cause it to be impeded. However, Singer's solution also is not infallible in its guarantee. The assumption that donating money directly alleviates suffering is taken for granted as a given, even though it could lead to donations being intercepted by corrupt governments or roving gangs in the countries the donations seek to aid. Alleviating suffering is more complex than the exchange of capital for saving human lives.

In further response to my reevaluation of his proposed ethical system, Singer's emphasis on the practicality of the principle would most likely lead him to disregard my counterexamples and instead challenge the purpose of my essay in response to the goal of his own. If ethics should dictate how decisions ought to be made for the sake of goodness, Singer may challenge what the goal of this essay is by accusing it of obfuscating the issue with discourse for the sake of discourse, impeding an altruistic message and the good it can do. However, this essay does not seek to support the inequalities and suffering of the current system. Rather, this analysis challenges the values that Singer prioritizes in his moral theory by raising the possibility of alternative values. Furthermore, this analysis does not entirely invalidate Singer's principle, but clarifies that the correct course of action is not the radical one Singer concluded it to be.